MONTHLY LABOR MARKET REPORT

Jobs are growing, and some searches are taking longer.

How people are working, getting hired and changing jobs, with what is slower alongside what is stronger. Every number is shown with its source, and survey estimates with their margin of error.

Swipe →

Source: NextChapter White Collar Employment Report, September 2026, Version 1.72 (revised October 13, 2026).

1 · WHAT IS IMPROVING

612,000 jobs were added in the first nine months of 2026.

232K

Jobs added in the same months of 2025 (current data)

612K

Jobs added January–September 2026

> September was slow, at +29,000 jobs, and July was revised to a loss. With labor force growth slower, that is slow growth rather than a contraction.

Source: BLS employment data via FRED, as reported in the NextChapter report (Chapter 02). Job counts are survey-based estimates with margins of error.

1 · WHAT IS IMPROVING

There is about one job opening for each unemployed person.

0.94

Openings per unemployed person, a year ago

1.01

Openings per unemployed person, August 2026

> The catch: each opening yields fewer hires. There were 0.73 hires per opening in January–August 2026, against 0.82 in 2019.

Source: BLS JOLTS; NextChapter calculation (Chapters 02 and 05). Hires and openings are not matched one to one. Survey-based estimates carry 90% margins of error.

1 · WHAT IS IMPROVING

People who change jobs are getting 5.0% raises.

3.6%

Wage growth for people who stay in their job

5.0%

Wage growth for people who change jobs, August 2026

> Moving is paying more than staying. That is a measure of pay for people who found a new job, not a forecast for any one search.

Source: Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta Wage Growth Tracker (September 10, 2026 release), as reported in the NextChapter report (Chapter 02). Survey-based estimates carry 90% margins of error.

2 · WHERE SEARCHES ARE TAKING LONGER

Long searches among managers and professionals are about a third more common.

0.56%

of the white-collar labor force out 27+ weeks, January–August 2025

0.75%

of the white-collar labor force out 27+ weeks, January–August 2026

> The change is +0.18 points (±0.08), larger than its 90% margin of error. This measures how long a search takes, not why.

Source: NextChapter analysis of Census CPS microdata, January–August averages, not seasonally adjusted (Chapter 01). 90% margin of error shown.

2 · WHERE SEARCHES ARE TAKING LONGER

27.1% of all unemployed people have been looking 27+ weeks.

23.6%
of all unemployed, September 2025

27.1%
of all unemployed, September 2026

Aged 55–64: among unemployed white-collar workers, 39% have been out 27+ weeks, up from 27%.

Beyond the 90% margin of error.

Sources: BLS, September 2026 (all unemployed); NextChapter analysis of Census CPS microdata, January–August averages (aged 55–64; Chapter 06). This report does not assert that AI caused these changes.

3 · WHAT PUBLIC PROGRAMS ARE ADDING

Reemployment services have randomized-trial evidence.

1.99

fewer weeks on unemployment insurance (95% interval 1.75 to 2.24)

23,549

claimants in the Rhode Island RESEA trial

> Selected claimants also had about $1,153 higher annualized wages (3.5%). Limits: one state, and all claimants rather than professionals only; results vary by state.

Source: Li, Pearson-Merkowitz and Yokum, Rhode Island RESEA Program Evaluation (University of Maryland, October 13, 2025), as summarized in the report (Chapter 13A). Trial estimates carry their own intervals.

3 · WHAT PUBLIC PROGRAMS ARE ADDING

Workforce Pell began July 1, and Texas is building the outcome data.

Pell aid for short-term training. Programs of 8 to 15 weeks; they must meet 70% completion and 70% job-placement rates.

Texas approvals. Five community colleges approved for nine programs (health care, welding, machining, electric power), per the governor's October 2 announcement.

$10.4 million Labor Department grant ($10,467,300 over four years) to a 37-college consortium to build the data colleges need to qualify programs.

Outcome evidence: none yet.

Sources: U.S. Department of Education; Labor Department; Texas Governor's office (October 2, 2026), per the report (Chapter 13A). One news report counted two approved colleges; the report names both counts.

3 · WHAT PUBLIC PROGRAMS ARE ADDING

Funding is increasingly tied to outcomes.

Nearly $162M

Registered Apprenticeship pay-for-performance awards, announced July 7, 2026

> Sponsors are paid as apprentices reach verified retention and progression milestones, and at least 85% of each award goes to sponsors. Outcome evidence: none yet.

How strong is the evidence? Strong for one program, descriptive for others, and absent for the newest. We say which is which.

Source: Labor Department news release 26-1012-NAT (July 7, 2026), as summarized in the report (Chapter 13A).

FREE · MONTHLY · WITH MARGINS OF ERROR

Read the report and the open data.

The code, data and methods are open. The report also says what it does not show, including that it does not assert that AI caused any of these changes.

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Justin Kulla, Founder and CEO

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